devastation, it is thought that the tiger population in 1900 was between 25,000 and 40,000. So, where were the lions?

As we have seen, the British encountered the lion quite early when Sir Thomas Roe dealt with one during Emperor Jehangir's time. Accounts of lion hunts in Aurangzeb's time suggest that the animal was still fairly common in the beginning of the eighteenth century. However, their numbers seem to have dramatically fallen by the early nineteenth century. My guess is that it was a combination of two important factors. First, the rapid improvement in gun technology made it very easy to kill an animal that prefers to live in the open. Second, the collapse of Mughal power also removed imperial protection. Any rebel, mercenary or local despot with a gun could go out and shoot the animal.

Still, there was a sizeable population of lions in North India in the early 1800s. We know that William Frazer shot eighty-four lions in the 1820s and took great pride in having been personally responsible for the extinction of the species in Haryana [21] . In the 1830s, Maharaja Ranjit Singh's lancers were spearing these cats near Lahore. There are reports of large lion populations in Central India in the 1850s and of ten lions being shot in Kotah, Rajasthan, in 1866. Then, suddenly, the lions virtually disappear except for a small population in Gujarat. What happened?

In my view, habitat loss was far more devastating than hunting. According to Angus Maddison's estimates, between 1820 and 1913, the country's population jumped from 209 million to 303 million (not counting the rest of the subcontinent). This meant that agriculture had to be scaled up in order to feed this growing population. At the same time, the railways made it possible to export agricultural commodities like opium and raw cotton. In short, the open ranges needed by the lion (and the cheetah) were just gobbled up by farming within a few generations. The tiger too suffered habitat loss, but did better than the lion because it can survive in hilly and swampy terrain that is less conducive to agriculture.

By the late nineteenth century, there were reports that perhaps only a dozen Asiatic lions were left in the wild in the Gir forests of Junagarh, a princely state in Gujarat. The actual number was almost certainly larger, but